McArthur-Burney Falls Interpretive Association

April 2026 Quarterly Newsletter

Welcome Back!

Nearly 500 friends of the McArthur-Burney Falls Interpretive Association have subscrribed to our newsletter in the past. The 'quarterly' newsletter from MBFIA has been sporadic in recent years. We plan to revivie this tradtion and do our best to stick to a quarterly schedule. This newsletter is scheduled for early *April* and you can expect to see the next one in early *July* as America celebrates the Semiquincentennial of the signing of our Declaration of Independence. In the *October* newsletter we will look forward to Heritage day. And to finish the year, the *January* 2027 newsletter will start the Centennial celebration of the McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park.

Upcoming Dates in 2026

- Sunday, April 5 – Easter
- April 1 – Seasonal openings begin.
- April 1 – Visitor Center and Store open
- Specific dates general store, , reserved camping
- Sunday, May 10 – Mother's Day
- Friday, May 22-Sunday, May 24 – Memorial Day Weekend (Warning: Very busy roads.)
- Monday, May 25 – Memorial Day (adjusted)
- Saturday, May 30 – Memorial Day (traditional)
- Sunday, June 15 – Flag Day

- Friday, June 19 – Juneteenth
- Sunday, June 21 – Father's Day
- Saturday, July 4 – 250th Anniversary Independence Day
- Monday, September 7 – Labor Day
- Saturday, September 12 – MBFIA **Volunteer Appreciation Day** & Lunch
- Sunday, October 11 – McArthur-Burney Falls **Heritage Day Celebration**
- Monday, October 12 – Columbus Day
- October 31 – Most seasonal facilities close
- Wednesday, November 11 – Veterans Day
- Thursday, November 26 – Thanksgiving
- Friday, December 25 – Christmas
- Friday, January 1, 2027 – New Years Day

About MBFIA

The McArthur Burney Falls Interpretive Association (MBFIA) is an all-volunteer non-profit education organization that provides assistance and funding for activities which enhance the quality of visits to McArthur Burney Falls Memorial State

Park, Castle Crags State Park and Ahjumawi Lava Springs State Park. The association was founded in 1984 to promote greater appreciation of the cultural and natural history of the region.

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Donations

We are a group of volunteers who love and support our northern California State Parks. We operate gift shops, sell firewood and do other fund-raisers to help us help the parks!

All donations are used for educational and interpretive activities in the Park.

Did you enjoy the campfire and evening programs? These are supported by donations.

Did you or your child complete the Discovery Quest Challenge? The patch you received was paid for with donations.

Did you take a nature walk or a guided canoe trip on Lake Britten? These are supported by donations.

Is this Visitor Guide newspaper helpful and interesting? Donations paid for printing the paper.

Did you attend Heritage Day? Donations provide candle-making, beading, saw-bucking, rope-making, pine-doll building, apple cider press, and old time fiddle music. This celebration of life in the Intermountain Area in the 1870's is provided thanks to donations.

Donations for the Park are accepted by the McArthur-Burney Falls Interpretive Association. An organization of volunteers from the communities around the Park, the Association is also known as the Friends of the Falls. We love the Park and we know that you do as well.

We encourage every visitor to make a donation in any amount to support activities in the Park. Checks may be made payable to MBFIA, Box 777, Burney CA 96013. Donation envelopes are available in the kiosk at the entrance or in the Visitor Center. We will list donors in next year's Visitor Guide.

Board Members

- President Jim Sacson
- Vice President: Mark Downie
- Secretary: Ann Sacson
- Treasurer Emiritus: Jaci White
- Webmaster: Bob Boyce
- Media Rep: Craig Harrington
- Newsletter Editor: Tony Otto
- Volunteer: Susan Lamke
- Alice Hoveman
- Bill McSweeney
- Jill Overbaugh
- Tom Stockton

Firewood

The MFBIA has firewood in 0.8 cubic foot bags available at Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet. The cost is $10/1 bag, $18/2 bags, and $25/3 bags.

The firewood is gathered consectetur adipiscing elit, sed do eiusmod tempor incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua. Ut enim ad minim veniam, quis nostrud exercitation ullamco laboris nisi ut aliquip ex ea commodo consequat. Duis aute irure dolor in reprehenderit in voluptate velit esse cillum dolore eu fugiat nulla pariatur. Excepteur sint occaecat cupidatat non proident, sunt in culpa qui officia deserunt mollit anim id est laborum.

Mission

The objectives.of the Association are:

1) Promote the educational and interpretive activities of the State Park System, principally in McArthur Burney Falls Memorial State Park, Castle Crags State Park and Ahjumawi Lava Springs State Park

2) Through effective leadership and operation of the McArthur Burney Falls Interpretive Association.

3) Actively engage in fundraising activities to provide financial support for:
   a) Heritage Day
   b) Interpretive Staff and Programs
   c) Volunteer in Parks Program Support
   d) Visitor Center
   e) Other support expenses

4) Plan and co-manage all events and activities of the Annual Heritage Day Event with State Park personnel at no cost to the Intermountain Community and outside visitors.

5) Produce and make available to the park visitor, by sale or free distribution, suitable interpretive and educational literature, including books, maps, pamphlets, and DVD's.

6) Buy, sell, and distribute state-printed and other publications, which enhance visitor knowledge of the geologic history of Burney Falls, volcanic legacy of the Cascade Range and related topics (biodiversity of Northern California).

7) Acquire display materials or objects pertaining to the Cultural History and Natural History of the Intermountain area for the purpose of adding them to the interpretive collection in the Visitor Center.

8) Assist in the development and improvement of interpretive features, including signs, markers, and audio/visual stations, when aid is requested by the State Park system.:

President's Message

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2026 MBFIA Annual Plan

Board Business

1. Raise $86,000 through donations, sales of Visitor Center Merchandise, Firewood and Visitor Guide Ads to support Interpretive Services at McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial, Castle Crags and Ahjumawi Lava Springs State Parks.

2. Continue to recruit and expand Board membership with focus on public relations and financial expertise.

3. Hire a bookkeeping service to manage revenue and expenditure throughout the season.

4. Focus on Board development to provide leadership for Board projects; succession planning and training for transitioning of responsibilities.

5. Provide opportunities for donations from the public on the MBFIA website and donation envelopes at the park with a goal of raising $3,500.

6. Raise $2,500 coordinating the sale of one memorial table at MBF.

7. Develop policies and procedures that will enable the sale of Memorial Benches for implementation in 2026.
8. Continue partnership with the Mountain Jewels Ranch to recycle 4,000 pounds of plastic, aluminum and glass raising $2,100.
9. Solicit a minimum of 9 businesses raising $3,000 for Visitor Guide Advertising at MBF.
10. Continue to invest $20,000 in money market account @4% interest.

Visitor Centers Reopening

1. Operate full-time Visitor Center Gift Shops at McArthur Burney Falls and Castle Crags State Parks with goal of raising $37,000.
2. Provide access to MBF Visitor Center for 12,000 visitors, 5 days a week.
3. Expand sale merchandise inventory and continue to support the new T-shirt designs at both MBF and Castle Crags.

Firewood Production and Sales

1. Provide funding in the amount of $12,000 for processing 4,000 bundles of firewood for sale to campers at MBF and Castle Crags State Parks.
2. Manage the sale of Firewood, stocking weekly supplies at campsites and entry wood sheds, with a goal of raising $37,000 in revenue.

Interpretive Services Projects

1. Support the design and/or replacement of two Interpretive Panels in McArthur-Burney Falls and one panel in Castle Crags State Parks.
2. Finish the replacement/repair the campfire benches; mill wood from downed trees providing material for replacement and repair of decaying benches in the campfire arena to complete the project.

Interpretive Program Support

1. Print 35,000 20-page Visitor Guides for Mc Arthur Burney Falls Memorial State Park.
2. Order 2,000 2026 Discovery Challenge Patches for MBF.
3. Revise the Discovery Challenge Quiz Questions in the MBF.
4. Provide funding in the amount of $1,000 to Shasta Wildlife Rescue and Rehabilitation to hold 10 camp fire presentations with live birds and animals for campers at MBF and Castle Crags State Park.
5. Plan and schedule Heritage Day in October for 1200 visitors. Continue to re-envision the day with a broader look at the natural and human impact on the land, keeping in place what has been a successful involvement by local folks.
6. Support at least 2 Art In The Park events at MBF State park in cooperation with local artists.

SPECIAL PROJECTS

In partnership with the State Park district, define and propose special projects that could be funded or managed by the Association at each park. Possible projects could include:

1. Develop Volunteer Work Days that include minor amenities for the bathrooms, trash pick-up on the trails, beach rehabilitation, campfire bench repair and/or other such work projects.

2. Support volunteers and staff at both parks during the season that will include water/drinks/snacks and end of season BBQ.
3. Develop plans to build memorial benches from local downed trees for interested customers in both parks.

Board Meeting Highlights - January to March 2026

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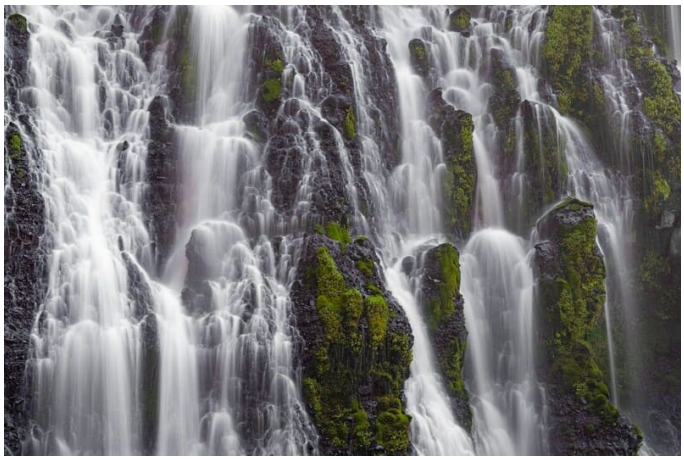
A Wonder of the World

SecretSanFrancisco.com recently posted an article about Burney Falls. Whether future President Teddy Roosevelt described it as the 'Eighth' or just 'A' Wonder of the world is up to interpretation, the falls are certainly wonderous. *Ed Note: See the **On the Internet** section at the end for a link.*

About the Three State Parks

McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park



Courtesy CA State Parks

The park is within the Cascade Range and Modoc Plateau natural region, with forest and five miles of streamside and lake shoreline, including a portion of Lake Britton.

The park's centerpiece is the 129-foot Burney Falls, which is not the highest or largest waterfall in the state, but possibly the most beautiful. Additional water comes from springs, joining to create a mist-filled basin. Burney Creek originates from the park's underground springs and flows to Lake Britton, getting larger along the way to the majestic falls.

The park's landscape was created by volcanic activity as well as erosion from weather and streams. This volcanic region is surrounded by mountain peaks and is covered by black volcanic rock, or basalt. Created over a million years ago, the layered, porous basalt retains rainwater and snow melt, which forms a large underground reservoir.

Within the park, the water emerges as springs at and above Burney Falls, where it flows at 100 million gallons every day.

Burney Falls was named after pioneer settler Samuel Burney who lived in the area in the 1850s. The McArthurs were pioneer settlers who arrived in the late 1800s. Descendants were responsible for saving the waterfall and nearby land from development. They bought the property and gave it to the state as a gift in the 1920s.

MBFIA President Jim Sacson with the heavily flowing falls, March 3, 2026

This year, we experienced heavy snow in mid-February so the falls were flowing exeptionally heavy.

Cellular service in the park continues to improve, so you should be able to find a signal as you travel the roads.

Visitor Information for the Falls:

McArthur Burney Falls Memorial State Park entrance kiosk is open now, but closed in the off-season. Please bring exact change or credit/debit cards to pay by APM (Automatic Payment Machine) which is located just pass the entrance kiosk in front of the visitor center.

- Park Day-Use Fee - $10 Per Vehicle
- Overnight Camping - $35 Per Night (Includes One Vehicle).
- Additional Overnight Camping Vehicles - $10 Per night.

Warnings for Falls Vistors:

McArthur Burney Falls State Park experiences extremely high visitation beginning in April and continuing through October. Most weekends all summer the park will fill to capacity and entrance into the park is subject to closure due to limited parking availability. Visitors should expect traffic delays on State Highway 89 for up to an hour prior to entering the park due to the increased visitation experienced at this park. It is illegal to park along Highway 89 outside of the park for a mile either direction. If you park along Highway 89 your vehicle will be subject to citation and tow. The speed limit is 55 mph along Highway 89 and utilized by a large volume of semitrucks, it is not recommended to walk along the highway. If you arrive to find the entrance closed due to full capacity, please return at a later time - typically after 4:00 p.m.

The park cannot admit entrance to vehicles over 32 feet for day-use or camping. Additionally, only a limited number of oversized vehicles (less than 32 feet in length) will be admitted into park. Oversized vehicles will only be allowed to park in the Lake Britton parking lot (approximately 1.5 miles walk to the falls) on Fridays, Saturdays, and Sundays.

Due to limited parking capacity, McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park cannot accommodate entry, drop-offs or parking of tour busses until further notice.

Castle Crags State Park

Courtesy of California State Parks, 2026.

Majestic Castle Crags have inspired enduring myths and legends. More than 170 million years old, these 6000-feet tall granite spires in the Castle Crags

Wilderness border the northwestern edge of Castle Crags State Park.

Castle Crags State Park offers a variety of camping, picnicking, hiking, and fishing opportunities.

The park has 76 developed campsites that are each equipped with a picnic table, food locker, and a fire ring. Flush toilets, showers, and drinking water are available near each campsite. Picnic sites are located along the Sacramento River and at the awe-inspiring Vista Point.McArthur Burney Falls State Park experiences extremely high visitation beginning in April and continuing through October. Most weekends all summer the park will fill to capacity and entrance into the park is subject to closure due to limited parking availability. Visitors should expect traffic With 28 miles of hiking trails, everyone can enjoy a mild stroll or an invigorating adventure. From the Vista Point parking area, a quarter mile accessible trail leads visitors to Vista Point where there are dramatic views of Castle Crags, Mount Shasta, and nearby Grays Rocks. Gentle and shaded, the mile long Root Creek Trail guides hikers along an accessible path to a year round flowing creek.

The most popular and challenging route is the Crags Trail which leads adventures to the base of Castle Dome where the views are simply breathtaking. The Pacific Crest Trail winds through the Park as well. Castle Crags State Park is often a respite for the weary hikers of this 2,650 mile trek from Mexico to Canada.

The Sacramento River flows through the park and has several access points that allow for fishing and hiking. Facilities at Riverside include camping and picnicking sites as well the famed pedestrian suspension bridge that crosses the Sacramento River.

Ahjumawi Lava Springs State Park

"Where the waters come together...." is a translation of the California Indian word Ahjumawi, which is also the self describing word used by the band of Pit River of Indians who still inhabit the area.
Ahjumawi is a place of exceptional, even primeval, beauty. Brilliant aqua bays and tree studded islets only a few yards long dot the shoreline of Ja-She Creek, Crystal Springs, and Horr Pond. Over two thirds of the area is covered by recent (three to five thousand years) lava flows including vast areas of jagged black basalt.
The park's backcountry is charactarized as wilderness with extremely rugged lava rock. Visitors should prepare adequately for their visit. While there are over twenty miles of park trails by which to explore this beautiful geographical wonder, please be advised that travel off the trails requires proper preparation and equipment. Be sure someone knows where you are going and when you expect to return.

Welcome

From State First District Assemblywoman Heather Hadwick

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Meet

The Newsletter Editor Tony Otto

I visited the falls and nearby Lassen park during summer vacation a couple of times as a primary grade schooler and as a junior high student. Those were great memories, along with coming around a curve on CA-299 and coming upon a VW Beetle sized boulder that had fallen on the upward lane of the highway. I'm not sure my Dad was as amused as I was. Fifty plus years later, the opportuntity to live in Fall River Mills came about. Now I live a few short miles from the falls. I was asked to join the Board of Directors of the MBFIA and I greatfully accepted. When the need to resume the quarterly newsletter arose, I willingly took on the challenge.

Falls Visitor Center

The MBFIA operates the visitors center at the main parking lot above the falls. There you will find informative panels about the , the park, and the local flora & fauna. Several art exhibits are displayed in the center, including: List of artists.

Ed. Note: See this quarter's featured artist below.

Visitor Center Store

At the center, these items are for sale:

- $30 Shirts
- $29.95 Caps
- Momentos from Pine Cones
- Artwork

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Featured Artist this Quarter:

Marla Nolan

I am a disabled artist living in Northern California with my wonderful husband Tim and black shelter cat Meowtian. I retired from my beloved career as Pharmacist in 2015 due to worsening chronic illness.

I have been creative my whole life. When I was still working, before my hands lost fine function and developed deformities from arthritis, I was often working on needle work, usually of a famous painting. Here is the last piece I completed:

After I left work, an artist friend gave me a Sumi-E book thinking this might be something I could do. Enjoying it but wanting color, I found an online watercolor work at your own pace course in 2019. I fell in love with the beautiful transparency and glow of the medium. I became excited that you could express with paint not just beauty but the feelings you have about a place, person, or thing just by manipulating colors, light, and values. Painting for me is a distraction from pain and disability, and a time of meditation that brings me great joy!

With my website, my works, and my social media presence, I want to highlight how art can be beneficial as a therapy in chronic disease management (based on my experience). I hope my paintings will bring you the same happiness I felt during their creation each time they are viewed. Looking forward is easier now with a purpose, continual learning, community, and painting.

Ed. Note: See links to Marla's website in the 'On the Internet' section at the bottom.

Burney Falls General Store

Conveniently located within Burney Falls State Park, the Burney Falls General Store is your go-to stop for essential supplies and quick refreshments. Whether you're stocking up for a day hike, grabbing snacks for the trail, or need last-minute camping supplies, the store has you covered. You'll find a variety of cold drinks, tasty treats, and basic camping necessities—all surrounded by the beauty of the park's towering pines and tranquil atmosphere. Friendly staff and a rustic setting make it a welcoming stop for campers and day visitors alike.

Ed. Note: See the link to the General Store website in the 'On the Internet' section at the end of this newsletter.

Job Openings

MBFIA Bookkeeper

The Association needs a bookkeeper/treasurer to join the Board on a volunteer basis. This is a great way to give back to the community, working with a group of like-minded people who get a kick out of helping to improve three local State parks, including MacArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park. Great for a retired person who wants to keep active up to 10 hours a week. Knowledge of Quick Books helpful. *Contact Board President Jim Sacson at (530) 513-7102.*

Camp Hosts

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Questions Answered

Questions from the public on our website are answered by the Webmaster. Some of the more interesting answers for the previous quarter are:

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Memorial Tables

We are thrilled to offer you a limited opportunity to purchase an engraved memorial table to be placed in the Park for years to come! Here's your opportunity to contribute a tax-deductible gift to the Park and to create an everlasting memory of a special time at the park or in honor of a family member or friend, while contributing to the Friends of the Falls at the same time! Contact Bill McSweeney at: calpacker@comcast.net or 415-726-3241 for information and an application!The MBFIA builds memorial tables and places them throughout the parks. They can be purchased for $2800. Each end can have memorial information etched into the bench.

Tribute

A Tribute to Generations of Families Who Vacation At Burney Falls

For over forty years and probably more, families have gathered at McArthur Burney Falls Memorial State Park to spend time together. Grandparents, Uncles & Aunts, Cousins, Moms, Pops, and children camping, swimming, fishing, hiking, cooking, sleeping under the stars, roasting marshmallows, singing, and making strong memories. You may find their names on tables and benches throughout the park in memory of loved ones.
We would like to acknowledge the families that call this park home and have supported its interpretive services for at least the last ten years. The ones we know about are listed below. If you are not on the list, please let us know who you are and how long your family has been trekking to Northern California to spend time at our beautiful park. Just complete the form below or email the information to friends@ burneyfallspark.org

Family Name:	
Number of Years vacationing here:	
Memories or Family Members you would like to share:	

Tribute to Families that call McArthur Burney Falls Home

- The Ashby Family – Susan, Bill, Bryan, Leslie & Brayden - 46 years
- The Busalacchi Family – 51years
- The Calkin Family – In Memory of Sandy Stefenoni
- The Case Family & the Kelly's Wishes Foundation - In Honor of Kelly Case Moulton
- The Coughlin Family – In memory of Rober Vajretti and his Burney Legacy - 45 Years
- The Damato Family – 52 years
- The Doo Family – In honor of Jack & Cathy Doo
- The Garcia Family – In Memory of Dale Berliner - 30 years
- The Germeraad Family – In Honor of Stewart & Clare Smith – 4 generations
- The Gomez Family – In Memory of Sandy Stefenoni - 46 years
- The Gutilla Family- In Honor of Daniel Ries. Our families have been visiting Burney Falls for decades.
- The Hesselroth & Russell families - In memory of Mrs. Pamela Russell and her husband, John, who began vacationing at McArthur Falls in the 1970's. – 50 Years
- Kamp Kearney – - A family tradition for more than 46 years and keeping the tradition going for 100 more in honor of Tim and Joy Kearney.
- The McKay Family – 52 years
- The Miller Family - 46 years
- Tom & Mary Pilla- Honoring John Roderick McArthur, nephew of Frank McArthur of the McArthur Family, who bequeathed the park to the citizens of California.
- The Stefenoni Family – 46 Years

- The Strickler Family
- The Taube Family
- The Towle Family – In Memory of Tom Garcia – 116 years
- The Van Aken Family – 62 years
- The Vitale Family – In Memory of Scott Lunger – 29 years
- The Wilbur Family – In Memory of Linda Wilbur - 51 years
- The Zwanziger Family – In honor of grandchildren Callen, Kassidy, Kamille and Chase- 60 years

Thank you all for your love and support of this beautiful park.

Friends of the Falls

Friends of Burney Falls provides education and interpretation and our programs highlight the Park's natural and cultural elements. Burney Falls offers hiking trails, flora and fauna, birds, squirrels and the like, camping, cabins and Lake Britton. Funds donated support Interpretive and educational activities, including guided hikes, Junior Ranger programs, campfire and craft activities, sing-alongs and group games. At Burney Falls, our Visitor Center includes a Gift Shop, as well as information about the geology, flora and fauna, cultural history and recreational opportunities in the park and the surrounding area. Our annual Heritage Day celebration in October offers weaving, cross-cut sawing, branding, candle-making, pine-doll making, apple cider pressing and Dutch Oven cooking. The Park has instituted a birding program, that includes guided bird identification walks, loaner binoculars plus a library of information. In addition, we have supported new native plants around the Visitor Center, with information about the plantings available for visitors.

We're also in the process of renewing our availability for sale and placement of memorial benches and picnic tables at the Park. Contact us for more details.

Contact Infomation

- MBFIA (McArthur-Burney Falls Interactive Association), PO Box 777, Burney 96013, friends@burneyfallspark.org
  - Board President Jim Sacson: jimsacson@gmail.com, (530) 513-7102
  - Webmaster Bob Boyce: webmaster@burneyfallspark.org
  - Newsletter Editor Tony Otto: tony.otto.frm@gmail.com, (530) 610-2133
- McArthur-Burney Falls Memorial State Park, 24898 CA Hwy 89, Burney, CA 96013, (530) 335-2777
  - Falls Ranger Justin Edwards, justin.edwards@parks.ca.gov, (530) 712-7275
- Castle Crags State Park, 20022 Castle Creek Road, Castella, CA 96017, https://castlecragspark.org/
  - Crags Ranger: Ryan Gray, ryan.gray@parks.ca.gov, (530) 353-8389
- Burney Falls Visitor's Center: (530) 335-3171

On the Internet

MBFIA (McArthur-Burney Falls Interpretive Association)

https://burneyfallspark.org/

https://www.parks.ca.gov/?page_id=28535

https://www.facebook.com/BurneyFallsPark/

https://burneyfallspark.networkforgood.com/

https://projects.propublica.org/nonprofits/organizations/680041373

Burney Falls General Store

https://burneyfallshospitality.com/

MacArthur-Burney Memorial State Park

https://www.parks.ca.gov/?page_id=455

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/McArthur%E2%80%93Burney_Falls_Memorial_State_Park

https://www.facebook.com/mbfmsp/

https://castlecragspark.org/

https://www.tripadvisor.com/ShowUserReviews-g32125-d102684-r240734010-McArthur_Burney_Falls_Memorial_State_Park-Burney_California.html

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Castle_Crags

https://www.reddit.com/r/norcalhiking/comments/1l2y6v9/mcarthur_burney_falls/

https://wilderness.net/visit-wilderness/?ID=103

Castle Crags State Park

https://www.parks.ca.gov/?page_id=454

Ahjumawi Lava Springs State Park

https://www.parks.ca.gov/?page_id=464

https://www.visitcalifornia.com/experience/ahjumawi-lava-springs-state-park/

https://www.shastacascade.com/account/ahjumawi-lava-springs-state-park

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ahjumawi_Lava_Springs_State_Park

July Featured Artist: Marla Nolan

https://www.rheum2cre8art.com/

https://linktr.ee/rheum2cre8art

Secret San Francisco Article

https://secretsanfrancisco.com/burney-falls-california-eighth-wonder-of-the-world/